

in C, composed in 1836.

Schumann proposed marriage in 1837, but Clara's father refused permission and banned Schumann from the house. This was hardly an irrational reaction, given that Clara was a highly gifted 18-year-old with a fine career ahead of her and Schumann a man of evident emotional instability and uncertain financial prospects. There followed a long period of clandestine meetings and exchange of love letters. The young couple's struggle to marry against the father's veto ended up in the courts, where a judge eventually ruled in their favor. They married in 1840 and the first of their eight children was born the following year.

The year of song

For Schumann the composer, 1840 was the "year of song." He wrote almost 140 songs, including *Dichterliebe*, a worthy successor to the song cycles of his hero Schubert. Clara encouraged her husband to embark on orchestral works, leading to the First Symphony, premiered with Felix Mendelssohn conducting in 1841, and the famous Piano Concerto, completed in 1845. Schumann considered his secular oratorio *Paradise and the Peri*, written in 1843 and based on the Irish poet Thomas Moore's *Lalla-Rookh*, to be his finest work. He also produced much chamber music during this period, including the exuberant Piano Quintet of 1842. But his style did not appeal to contemporary taste and he failed to attract a popular following.

Mendelssohn found Schumann a teaching post at the Leipzig Conservatory to supplement his income from journalism, but Clara was undoubtedly the family's chief breadwinner, her piano performances attracting large audiences. When the couple undertook a concert tour of